me." Fazal gradually realised that it was Guddu's underdog credentials which made him easy to relate to. "Everybody wants to see a story '*ki main bhi mitti se utth ke pahunch jaaoon upar*' [where even I can rise from the dirt to the top] and conquer it all," he adds. In season 2, the 35-year-old actor made it a point to ensure that Guddu doesn't swear. "Nobody missed it or noticed it," he says. "Certain things we can take responsibility for."

Last year, Fazal and his partner, actress Richa Chadha, took on another responsibility—production. Having set up Pushing Buttons Studios, the couple have announced their first feature, one in which they won't be acting. "We wanted this to be a medium where people through us could move to higher prospects," he says. "The idea that you enter a system and you get caged in it has bothered me. You don't grow, you get lost and you get cynical. It has to keep flowing."

Fazal himself, one can see, is in full flow. After finishing *Death on the Nile* promotions for the fourth time (the film was scheduled to release in 2019 but was delayed multiple times because of Covid), he resumes work on *Khufiya*, a Vishal Bhardwaj-directed Netflix spy drama with Tabu. He has also finished playing a spy, albeit one "who makes Guy Ritchie's life hell", in his next international project, *Kandahar*. Then it is time to get into the shoes of Guddu Bhaiya again. It's the equivalent of shooting three films, but it's worth all the effort. "Hidden behind all the violence, after you peel the first layer, the next one is pure emotion," he says. ■

–Suhani Singh

FILMS

DEAD MEN WALKING

*The zombies in **ADITYA SARPOTDAR'S** Marathi comedy,* Zombivli, *will make you laugh and introspect*

Unlike, say, Hollywood or even the South Korean entertainment industry, India's zombie cinema output has been meagre. Our various film industries' contributions to this genre have been limited—*Go Goa Gone* (2013), the Netflix shows *Ghoul* (2018) and *Betaal* (2020), a Dibakar Banerjee short for *Ghost Stories* (2020). Director Aditya Sarpotdar, a fan of Korean zombie period drama *Kingdom* (2019, Netflix), wanted to change that. "It is quite shocking that this genre hasn't seen more," he says. Sarpotdar's Marathi film *Zombivli*, recently released in theatres, fills that gap. In it, zombies descend upon Dombivli, a city in Thane, Maharashtra.

Though the zombie comedy has all the cliches we associate with the walking dead—groaning, slow movements, spooky faces—Sarpotdar and his writers also make it a point to highlight several socio-economic schisms and environmental concerns. *Zombivli* sucks you in with that trademark survival-of-the-smartest narrative, but also touches on the region's water woes. We see people's mindsets can be comparably toxic. Someone living in a swanky high-rise looks down at a neighbouring slum and holds its residents responsible for the chaos. Written during the first lockdown, the pandemic weighed heavily on the minds of *Zombivli's* makers. "Trapped in our houses, I could see the class divide was rampant," says Sarpotdar. "There were only a handful of people who had access to information and treatment."

While *Zombivli* employs all the tropes of a zombie flick—thankfully with less blood and gore—it also rakes in a few laughs—most of them elicited by Sudhir (Amey Wagh), a character so petrified of the revived corpses, he is often clueless about how to handle the escalating crisis. In one of his initial encounters with zombies, he cries out for his mother, flashes a photo of Lord Ganesha and chants. The situation enables Sarpotdar to highlight that women can also save the day as Sudhir's pregnant wife steps up. "When everyone was panicking [during the pandemic], women were more sorted to handle things," he says.

Sarpotdar hopes his feature will inspire more filmmakers to make "local, desi zombie films". But if no one does, he has plans to turn *Zombivli* into a franchise. The ending certainly affords the possibility of a sequel. While making the case that zombie films are here to stay, he says, "A zombie is like a virus that hits us. We [now] know that this situation is much more plausible, and the idea of humans turning into bloodthirsty individuals is, of course, fascinating." ■ **–Suhani Singh**



IN *ZOMBIVLI*, ADITYA SARPOTDAR HIGHLIGHTS SEVERAL SOCIO-ECONOMIC SCHISMS

